The other possibility was that the NLD, and Ms Suu Kyi herself, were just as hostile to the Rohingyas as the former military governments. Hints of this attitude were already abundant. Since its formation in the late 1980s, the NLD had always echoed the conventional sectarian narrative about the Rohingyas: that they are ‘Bengalis’ who had no innate right to live in Myanmar. The NLD casually parroted the ultra-nationalist line that the Rohingyas were illegitimately transplanted from British India during the colonial period after 1824.

‘Burmese identity’ is a fraught concept. The borders the state inherited from the British bore little relationship to the distribution of the various ethnic groups in the region, or to history. At best, the history of the region gives us a Burmese cultural core along the Irrawaddy River and its main tributaries. But the territory the country found itself with in 1948 extended well beyond that cultural core and included groups who straddled the borders with China or Thailand, and could identify more readily with those foreign powers, or indeed, who might want their own independent states. In 1948, the newly independent federal state of Burma represented no nation at all. But it was politically dominated by the Burmese ethnic nation.

Out of that difficult and complex cultural reality the Army had tried to build a coherent nation to correspond to the state ever since they first took power in 1962. The pillars of that new national identity had to be those traits that are common to all the residents in the country: adherence to Buddhism, and being light-skinned Indo-Chinese. Both of those traits apply to roughly 90 per cent of the population. The Rohingyas uniquely fall foul of both of those.

The question then is what are the positions of the NLD and Ms Suu Kyi herself on this approach to national identity in Myanmar? One of my arguments in this book is that the NLD’s leadership, and especially Aung San Suu Kyi, have always believed that the Rohingyas are an ‘alien’ population with no natural place in their Buddhist state, primarily because they are a Muslim community.

Even if Ms Suu Kyi and her government are still Buddhist nationalists, we could have reasonably expected them to be less hardline than the old military establishment. And in any case, they should be less inclined to violence. After all, one of the most remarkable aspects of Ms Suu Kyi’s career as a democracy advocate was that her movement was successful